



Incident handler's journal **Instructions:** As you continue through this

course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: February 24, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident
Tool(s) used	No tools were used
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? An organized group of Unethical hackers. • What happened? A ransomware security incident • When did the incident occur? Tuesday morning at 9:00 a.m. • Where did the incident happen? A small U.S. healthcare clinic. • Why did the incident happen? The incident happened because unethical hackers were able to access the company's systems using a phishing attack. After gaining access, the attackers launched their ransomware on the company's systems, encrypting critical files. The attackers' motivation appears to be financial because the ransom note they left demanded a large sum of money in exchange for the decryption key.
Additional notes	1. Were customers notified of the breach in the system? 2. How soon can we resolve this problem? 3. How could the health care company prevent an incident like this from

	occurring again? 4. Should the company pay the ransom to retrieve the decryption key?
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Date: February 26, 2026	Entry: 2
Description	Investigating a suspicious file hash
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? N/A • What happened? A malicious payload was executed on an employee's computer • When did the incident occur? N/A • Where did the incident happen? A financial services company • Why did the incident happen? This incident happened because an employee was sent an email containing an attachment. The employee downloaded the file, then entered the password to open the file. When the employee opened the file, a malicious payload was then executed on their computer.
Additional notes	Why did the threat actor attack the company? How many other employees received this email?

Date: February 27, 2026	Entry: 3
Description	Responding to a phishing incident
Tool(s) used	playbook
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who caused the incident? Clyde West ● What happened? A malicious attachment in a phishing email was sent to HR at inergy. ● When did the incident occur? Wednesday, July 20, 2022 ● Where did the incident happen? Inergy ● Why did the incident happen? The user opened a malicious email and opened malicious attachments or clicked links.
Additional notes	There are many grammatical errors in this email. The file hash sent in the email is known for being malicious.

Date: February 27, 2026	Entry: 4
Description	Reviewing a final report
Tool(s) used	none
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who caused the incident? N/A ● What happened? The company experienced a major security incident involving a data breach of over one million users. ● When did the incident occur? December 28, 2022 at 7:20 p.m., PT ● Where did the incident happen? A retail company ● Why did the incident happen? Due to a vulnerability in the e-commerce web application the attacker performed a forced browsing attack and accessed customer transaction data by modifying the order number included in the URL string of a purchase confirmation page. This vulnerability allowed the attacker to access customer purchase confirmation pages, exposing customer data, which the attacker then collected and exfiltrated.
Additional notes	● Perform routine vulnerability scans and penetration testing. ● Implement the following access control mechanisms: ○ Implement allowlisting to allow access to a specified set of URLs and automatically block all requests outside of this URL range. ○ Ensure that only authenticated users are authorized access to content.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes:

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not? Trying to perform a query with Splunk and Google SecOp was a little difficult to get a hang of because of the many commands that go into getting the information in a file and then to normalize that data.
2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course? My understanding has massively changed and grown since taking this course. It was very informative and helped me gain skills and pick up some tools I can use in my everyday life.
3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why? VirusTotal is by far my favorite tool to come out of this course with. This tool can help give me a second opinion, along with the community notes, on any file I receive or decide to download onto my PC.